



Visualizing the COVID-19 pandemic response in Canadian higher education: an extended photo essay

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ABSTRACT

The COVID-19 pandemic has brought unprecedented shifts to higher education globally, including Canadian universities. In this paper I utilize an extended photo essay method and narrative response to document the changes seen in my local university environment during the months of April through September 2020. Emerging literature and survey results concerning the Canadian academic condition during the pandemic are discussed alongside research diary entries and policy excerpts.

KEYWORDS

COVID-19; visual methods; photo essay; Canada; faculty

Introduction

The first two months of 2020 unfolded in hushed tones and concerned nods as many Canadians recalled the deadly spread of SARS in 2002–2003. A traveller returning from Wuhan, China to Toronto became Canada's first documented case of COVID-19 on 25 January 2020, just days after the Wuhan lockdown began. Soon thereafter, on 28 January, Vancouver's first case of COVID-19 was documented in another traveller who returned to Canada from Wuhan. While Canada's first cases of COVID-19 were connected to international travel from China, by the time the World Health Organization declared a global pandemic on March 11th, a significantly higher proportion of Canada's COVID-19 cases included individuals who had returned from the United States, Europe and specific countries such as Iran (Zhao et al. 2020). By mid-March, government had invoked the Quarantine Act of 2005, issuing travel restrictions for entry into Canada, with 14-day quarantine measures in place.

Early in the pandemic, Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau conveyed a solemn and collectivist tone for the country's response, himself in self-isolation as his wife, Sophie Grégoire Trudeau, tested positive for COVID-19 in March. The economic impact of the pandemic continues to be broadly felt across this vast country, but overall Canada has fared moderately well so far in terms of virus case counts. As of October 1, Canada (with a population around 38 million) had an overall COVID-19 case count of 160,535 (Government of Canada 2020). The losses have been high for the families of the more than 9500 who died due to the disease. Since mid-June, case counts have risen steadily, mostly among individuals in the 20–40 year-old age group. Despite these recent case load increases, daily hospitalizations and deaths have remain lower than the early days of the pandemic. Yet, as case rates climb, concerns regarding healthcare capacity and adequate protections for our vulnerable populations are renewed.

In comparison to many places in the world, the rest of Canada included, my province, British Columbia, has managed the COVID-19 crisis fairly well. We are guided by health officials who learned many hard lessons from the SARS epidemic, and we entered the pandemic with a provincial

surplus that afforded a swift response. Our provincial Chief Health Officer, Dr. Bonnie Henry, guides the public with a firm but compassionate stance, with informative daily briefings and reminders to 'Be kind, be calm and be safe'. Between 1 January and 1 October 2020, British Columbia (population around 5.1 million) had 9220 total COVID-19 cases, 779 of whom became hospitalized (8%), and 235 of whom died (3%) (BCCDC 2020). The province is projecting a fiscal year deficit of \$12.8 billion CAD, due to increased public health expenditures, pandemic recovery initiatives, and loss of tax revenue.

As the federal and provincial governments moved quickly to respond to the pandemic, universities in Canada also began updating emergency plans and creating new policies and procedures (Regehr and Goel 2020). In mid-March, most universities in Canada moved courses online and began remote work-at-home arrangements for staff and faculty (University Affairs 2020). The impact of the pandemic on Canada's higher education sector is yet to be extensively measured, but early indicators of the largely negative effects for students and faculty are coming to light (Firang 2020; CAUT 2020a). Fiscally, the mainly public Canadian higher education sector may encounter a cycle of retrenchment, as provincial governments face pandemic-related deficits and as previously anticipated tuition revenues might not be forthcoming (CAUT 2020b). While statistics for fall 2020 postsecondary enrolments are yet to be released, if there is a decline in international student enrolments, the economic impact will likely be unevenly felt across the sector, with variations by field of study and region (Usher 2020). The negative effects of the pandemic on individual Canadian academics may endure for some time, potentially increasing inequality within a sector already beleaguered by gender disparities and racialization (Johnson and Howsam 2020; Oleschuk 2020).

Attempting to make sense of the 2020 pandemic can be understood, meta-cognitively speaking, as academia's quintessential response to the unknown, coupled with a sector-wide existential crisis. For this special issue on the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on our lives, personally and professionally, I took a conscious approach toward self-expression and 'research creation' as a way to channel my mind/body reactions into something productive during this particularly stressful time. The Canadian Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council (SSHRC) defines research creation as 'an approach to research that combines creative and academic research practices, and supports the development of knowledge and innovation through artistic expression, scholarly investigation, and experimentation' (SSHRC, n.d.). In selecting a photo essay format, augmented by ethnographic data collection and my research diary, my contribution to this collection *focuses* on the changes the pandemic has brought to my work-life, my institution, and the Canadian university sector as a whole.

Before describing this documentary process and my reflections, it is essential to recognize that the Canadian university sector should be understood within the country's federal context (Eastman et al. 2019), where intergovernmental measures have enormous influence over our day to day lives as citizens and academics, especially when it comes to the present pandemic condition. Considering that both higher education and healthcare in Canada are constitutionally described as provincial concerns, public health and public education responses to the pandemic are inextricably intertwined and localized. While we may turn to the national news for an overall understanding of the country's state of affairs in these times, our own provincial health agencies are our primary sources of information such as daily case counts or changes to mask-wearing policies. However, Canadians are uniformly affected by federal border closures and benefit from the availability of pandemic relief measures, such as the Canadian Emergency Response Benefit (CERB) and the Canadian Emergency Commercial Rent Assistance (CECRA) for small businesses. Furthermore, even as provincial governments continue to support higher education institutions through annual operating fund allocations, the Canadian federal government is the primary source of external university research funding (Statistics Canada 2020a). As part of the federal pandemic response, \$275 million CAD was allocated for COVID-19 research, a large portion going toward projects underway at Canadian universities (Prime Minister of Canada 2020). In these ways, Canadian universities are central to the country's development of healthcare innovations and overall economic recovery measures,

but institutions face a ‘complex intergovernmental problem’ (El Masri and Sabzalieva 2020) in terms of navigating COVID-19 emergency conditions from a public health standpoint as well as the potentially dire economic impact of the pandemic at the local level, the extent to which we are just beginning to understand.

Methods

At this early stage we may not be able to fully comprehend the many-layered policy implications of the COVID-19 pandemic for higher education. Sensibly, the editors of this special issue have asked the contributors to respond from a more grounded stance: document what is happening, from our perspectives. Through the photo essay format, I locate my understanding of these conditions within the campus environment of my employing institution, the University of British Columbia, Vancouver, situated on the unceded territory of the Musqueam First Nation. I utilize a framework for photo documentation that stems from visual sociology, informed by notions such as the ‘visual ethnographic narrative’ (Harper 1987) and the ‘visual essay’ (Grady 1991; Heng 2020). I am particularly influenced by Pauwels’s (2015) discussion of photography’s research potential. He states, ‘The major strength of this scholarly form resides in the synergy of the distinct forms of expression that are combined – images, words, layout and design – and that add up to a scientifically informed statement’ (2015, 163).

The photo essay is held in constant tension between aesthetic and representational criteria, an expressive space afforded more often to photo journalists than academic researchers. As Chaplin said, ‘because we are operating within the discourse of social science rather than art, that aesthetic force cannot be allowed to overwhelm the social argument’ (2011, 244). Alternatively, Loveless declares in ‘Toward a Manifesto on Research-Creation’:

... I argue for research-creation as crucial to the development of new academic literacies that challenge traditional modes of knowledge in the university. Research-creation is a particularly potent way of speaking across and *with* disciplinary, political, ideological, methodological, and affective (diffractive) differences in the academy today. (Loveless 2015, 53, italics in original)

True to the spirit of the photo essay as a form of research-creation, I permitted a wide range of subject matter within this portfolio but held a tighter reign on technical practices that might be misconstrued as photo-manipulation. Acknowledging that all photography is socially constructed, I entered the ‘field’ of the university with my camera and a desire to see for both myself and others just *what was happening*.

In the sections that follow I present three consecutive photo essays that describe the conditions within my campus’ environment at the University of British Columbia between April and September 2020. Sequenced according to our local seasons (spring, summer, fall) and our institutional academic calendar (Winter 2, Summer, Winter 1), the images simultaneously portray moments in time/place and my somatic experiences. Each photo essay contains ten images, although due to space constraints just three per essay are reproduced here (nine overall). The complete photographic essays are available online (<http://www.amyscottmetcalfe.com/>). Within each section I offer temporal contextualization in the form of narrative description, contemporaneous policy texts, dated excerpts from my research diary (italicized), and recently released preliminary findings from institutional and national surveys of faculty with regard to the COVID-19 pandemic’s impact on academic life and work in Canada. The intent is to create a multimodal diary that collates my experiences as a Canadian academic during the early stages of the COVID-19 crisis in 2020.

Distancing (Spring)

In late January and early February, when many Vancouverites usually come together for Lunar New Year celebrations, we instead slipped into our rapidly changing social dynamic as friends and

neighbours self-isolated upon returning from holiday visits abroad. As restaurants and other gathering places became more and more vacant, I began to question my own travel plans. The spring of 2020 was meant to be a period of research site visits and guest lectures at various universities in Canada and the U.S. as I entered the second half of a year-long sabbatical. My final cross-border visit, to the archives at the University of Washington in Seattle, took place in February, prior to our full understanding of the viral outbreak that would overwhelm that region in the coming weeks. Conscious of the potential of the virus, but absent any directives to do otherwise, I proceeded to conduct my research in Seattle, feeling slightly paranoid but taking care to wash my hands at every opportunity.

March would not be so forgiving, or patient. The University of British Columbia (UBC) issued a statement on March 2nd, under the heading 'Coronavirus (COVID-19) – help prevent the spread of illness', noting that 'At this stage, the Public Health Agency of Canada continues to determine the risk as **low** for Canada' (UBC 2020a). In my research diary on 9 March, I outlined an optimistic publication plan for the March-June period, relishing in the sabbatical's promise of uninterrupted writing time. Those plans did not materialize, as my children's school closed for spring break and never re-opened. More email announcements came from the university: 'Faculties and departments are being asked to start planning how they can offer academic instruction and assessment through alternate means' (UBC 2020b). The next day, the message from our university president was clear, even as our remote capabilities were not:

As you know, governments and institutions around the world are grappling with the spread and impact of the COVID-19 outbreak. The situation continues to evolve and it has become an unprecedented scenario for the university. Today I am announcing the transition to **online classes effective Monday March 16, 2020 for the remainder of the term.** (UBC, 13 March 2020c, bolded lines in the original text)

By 16th March nearly every university in Canada had moved courses online and suspended in-person operations, in a series of cascading closure announcements over a period of a few days. The province of British Columbia declared a public state of emergency on 18th March. The U.S.–Canadian border closed. I wrote in my research diary on 21 March: *Daily closures. All work from home. Schools closed. Reframe all goals.*

My spouse our two elementary-school-age children were home with me, all of us attempting to work online in our faculty-staff housing apartment. Residing in our campus' 'live-work' community, work from home is redundant in my family's case, but we were unprepared to effectively create four workstations in our living space, using whatever supplies we managed to have on hand from our offices or schools since early March. The inability to enter or use my campus office was unexpectedly wrenching. I longed for a quiet space to hear myself think again.

More broadcast emails came from the university about research closures and distancing protocols. April arrived with notifications of extended work from home measures:

The situation regarding COVID-19 and the need for physical distancing has not yet eased, and is even more important now. In light of this, and continuing to follow guidance from the Provincial Health Officer, we will be extending the Remote Work Arrangements and on-campus research curtailment until the end of April. (UBC, 1 April 2020d)

I began taking photos of the campus on my daily walks as a way to make sense of what was happening around me, to me. In my research diary entry for 6 April I wrote: *Everything changes.* In big letters. (Figures 1–3).

My campus photography in April was both desperate and cathartic. Every step on the main area campus was moving toward a new expressive modality and moving physically away from the minor chaos of pandemic home-life and erratic home schooling occurring behind me in our cramped apartment. I moved closer to closed buildings, peering into windows to investigate the conditions of our classrooms. I noticed my reflection, and that of the empty campus surrounding me. I began framing the reflections of sky and trees as if they were positioned within the empty classrooms, reversing indoors and outdoors in places where only 'outside' was accessible. The resulting images



Figure 1. Photo by author, 2020.



Figure 2. Photo by author, 2020.



Figure 3. Photo by author, 2020.

represented the reversibility, disconnection and emptiness I felt in those moments. I uploaded the images to my photography website as an essay called 'Distancing'.

In the remainder of the month of April, I became increasingly irritated at the language my university was using to describe the work that was/was not happening:

Only exempted research such as critical COVID-19 research, essential clinical trials or exempted critical research continuity activities can continue. All research that is not time-critical and/or that would not result in significant data loss must be postponed. (UBC Research 2020)

The insinuation was that most of our research activity necessarily must cease, as if the laboratory model applied to the entire university, and as if the annual performance review cycles were not perpetually in motion. I wanted everything to be otherwise, writing in my diary on 17 April: *Revising and revising my task list and goals, finding it hard to complete anything but very basic things*. In truth, little was possible for many of us, as confirmed in conversations held outdoors with my academic neighbours, while our children played nearby. We struggled to do as much as work as we could while managing everything at home, enduring research setbacks unrecognized by a university administration that seemed more focused on institutional liability than our livelihoods. The situation was particularly hard on my pre-tenure neighbours; many of them seemed entirely at a loss for how to manage the stress of attempting to do work amid daycare and school closures, with our campus research facilities locked and off-limits. In my research diary on 27 April I wrote a rambling entry: *Our challenges as a family have to do with limited space for physical activity in our apartment, the closeness of siblings with different ages and interests, the extra help my son needs that takes away from the guidance I can offer to my daughter who is navigating complex online systems for schoolwork, their emotional states, being away from friends and their daily routines, feeling disconnected from my silent workspaces and movements, missing my daily activity and time to walk on campus, the short hours I get to work (in the early morning) that are over too quickly – just as I am getting started in thinking. I still don't have a desk, just a writing chair, but it is too exposed, too open to hearing the distractions of family*

activity as everyone wakes up and starts their day. I am struggling to have enough time to think and write, let alone read my students' work and provide feedback.

My department offered the opportunity to return to full-time work, postponing six months of my sabbatical to an unknown, future date. It was, and still is, uncertain as to when I will be able to visit my research sites in the U.S. due to border closures and public health measures. Taking a chance that my summer work duties would be somewhat flexible, although perhaps not entirely manageable with my children at home, I took the offer to return to regular work, with regular pay. I was grateful that I had a job, safe housing, and my family was healthy – undergirded of course by many layers of elite academic privilege, subsidized by public expenditure, and enabled by the 'success' of Canada's settler-colonial, state-making apparatus.

Prepping (Summer)

The end of the spring term brought news of an online summer term, and hints of online coursework for the rest of the year. The province of British Columbia issued its Restart Plan, including directives for the postsecondary system:

- Routine daily screening for all staff and students.
- Routine and frequent environmental cleaning.
- Clear policy for students and staff who have symptoms of a cold, flu, or COVID-19, with any coughing or sneezing not to attend classes, extra curricula activities, sports or work.
- Increased use of on-line learning balanced against the need of social interaction for learning and development.
- Early arrival and self-isolation for 14 days of international students. (Province of British Columbia 2020)

On 11 May we received news of the university's plans for the fall term:

During fall 2020, UBC will primarily offer larger classes online with selected smaller classes conducted in-person, adhering to physical distancing and other public health requirements. We will maintain a clear focus on ensuring high-quality face-to-face instruction, where possible, and high-quality remote instruction. Individual Faculties will be sharing updates about specific programs in the coming weeks. (UBC, 11 May 2020e)

An online fall term was expected, but the potential variability of class size and modes raised many questions and concerns from units across campus. It seemed we were being asked to do everything, everywhere, with a universal expectation of 'high-quality', even as the pandemic continued to spread worldwide and as provincial case-loads began to creep upward. The Dean of Education soon communicated that our Faculty's fall courses would be online, and our on-campus facilities would remain closed. The university library would remain closed as well. New students began sending me emails asking to defer entrance to their graduate programmes to the following semester, or the following year. We granted all requests.

As I answered or re-directed email questions from students about courses and visas, I remained stuck in the question that confounded the circumstances of my own life: will the schools open? My research diary entry for 11 May is a smattering of all of the uncertainties that we faced as an academic family: *Provincial discussions regarding school openings continue. No word regarding if or when our kids will go back to school. Realizing that work from home will likely continue through to January if not later.*

We learned that schools would open for a short period in June, with students attending a few days a week to enable reduced class sizes. Attendance was optional with remote learning continuing for those families that chose to educate their children at home. With viral case-loads rising nationally but somewhat contained provincially, we felt the mental health benefits of returning to school, however limited in scope, outweighed the risks. Our children's return to school was literally rejuvenating for them, although they were exhausted from the physicality of it. We were able to see just

how much our months of apartment-based isolation had worn them down both in body and spirit. With my children back in school, albeit only two days a week, I had the energy to reflect on my own state of mind: *Finding that I need more time or ways to regain sense of self. Easy to give a lot to family but not have much left for myself* (research diary, 6 June 2020). A working group was formed at the university to survey tenure-stream faculty about their experiences during the pandemic. The email invitation on 19 June asked, 'How has COVID-19 affected your ability to do your job effectively?' I completed the survey without hesitation.

As schools opened, and the province entered its restart phases, there was an increase in activity on campus. However, the uncertainty of the restart marked these otherwise hopeful summer days in ways that were visible in many locations of the university. Photos taken on my campus walks documented the changes in signage and the mixed messages displayed in our public spaces. A sign that read 'Welcome back!' was placed next to another that said 'Closed until further notice'. Yellow signs that said 'Field Closed' were replaced with green signs that said 'Enjoy this space responsibly'. Other signs depicted smiling cartoon figures and reminded us to 'Keep 2 metres, or 1 hockey stick apart'. These lighthearted official university placards contrasted with the painted graffiti and pasted posters left by campus visitors, perhaps students: 'Black Lives Matter', 'Say their names, Know their stories' and 'Solidarity: We are all we really have'. (Figures 4–6).

In July I began a second photo essay. 'Prepping' documented some of the visible changes to the campus that occurred over the summer months as various units prepared for an uncertain fall semester. New signage and visual cues like floor stickers were created to direct our movements throughout the campus: enter here, queue here, wait here. Outdoor spaces, newly augmented with picnic tables, were largely empty but ready for an increased volume of visitors to campus. Hand sanitizer stations were updated in buildings that remain closed, such as the library where stacks of empty boxes and old equipment marked 'Purell' awaited removal. Many doors remained locked, affixed



Figure 4. Photo by author, 2020.



Figure 5. Photo by author, 2020.



Figure 6. Photo by author, 2020.

with notices regarding increased campus security. The commonplace yellow 'Caution: automatic door' stickers could just as easily be read in part as the new zeitgeist: 'automatic caution'.

Preparations for another pandemic semester weighed heavily on faculty and staff as the summer filled with online teaching and course planning continued. New data on the impact of the pandemic on Canadian faculty was released in August by the Canadian Association of University Teachers (CAUT). Their survey of 4300 academic staff from all Canadian provinces showed that '84% of respondents reported somewhat or much higher stress levels due to the pandemic, balancing work and dependent care, challenges with research, and job insecurity' (CAUT 2020a). Significantly, the CAUT survey reported that 'only 1 in 4 feel that they are consulted before decisions that affect them are made' and that 'safe childcare, more access to mental health services, and technological assistance' were among the much needed resources identified by Canadian academics. The provincial Ministry of Education entered prolonged negotiation with the teachers' union regarding the school restart plan for the fall. Nothing was assured.

Waiting (Fall)

September ushers in the fall season and academic year at most Canadian institutions, typically beginning their semesters after the Labour Day holiday. While we knew we would enter the first term with online courses, we were uncertain what the January term would entail. With border closures and travel still restrictions in place, many international students would begin the term abroad. Before the semester began, we received an email from the university president that Term 2 (January–April 2021) would also be mostly online. Thinking of our new students who were waiting for news about when they could come to Canada, my eyes filled with tears upon reading this message. The effects of university-by-Zoom were already weighing upon our students. An entire academic year of remote teaching and learning would be a tremendous undertaking for all of us. More deferral requests showed up in my inbox. (Figures 7–9).



Figure 7. Photo by author, 2020.

I decided to create a final photo essay for this extended photographic examination, selecting the first day of classes in early September to see what might be visible on a university campus during an online semester. The ten images in the essay 'Waiting' depict a vacant expectancy within the academic environment as we entered the fall term. The efforts over the summer to prepare the campus were evident, but on this day, barely needed. Unlike previous first days of the academic year that I have experienced at UBC, the campus on that day was largely empty. The Welcome Centre was closed. Bike racks and outdoor seating areas were unused. Spaces typically filled with thousands of eager students, such as the Nest student centre, were hollow without their enthusiasm. Outdoor signage reminded us to keep two metres apart, and 'Thank you for practicing physical distancing'. Indoor signage in the re-opened student centre used a more succinct 'maintain distance' message with a graphic of two human torsos and a dotted line between them. We were in the short-hand phase of the pandemic, apparently.

On 9 September I wrote in my research diary: *New routines but hardly room for beginnings. It is too easy to be drawn into 'productivity' by the needs of the institution. Defending time and energy takes time and energy.* The following day the UBC Board of Governors would hear the preliminary findings from the UBC-Vancouver Tenure Track Faculty Survey on the Effects of COVID-19 (UBC TT Faculty Survey 2020), which included responses from 1094 faculty (a 47% response rate). The preliminary data showed that 73% of the faculty respondents indicated that their 'ability to focus/concentrate' and 'stress/anxiety/sadness' reduced their ability to work during the pandemic. Faculty also reported that concerns about work spaces, caregiving, time, and hardware contributed to their inability to be productive. Respondents noted that their teaching workloads increased by at least half, up to 145% of their regular loads. Service workloads increased for most faculty, with 62% reporting an increase in this area, and 46% of faculty stating that they were asked by their department, unit, Faculty, or the university to take on more service responsibilities during the pandemic. Of those respondents with children under the age of 18 (47%), 70% of them noted an increase in caregiving



Figure 8. Photo by author, 2020.



Figure 9. Photo by author, 2020.

responsibilities during this period. A large majority of the respondents (78%) described themselves as being responsible for either children or adults in need of care, with 56% of these faculty indicating an increase in caregiving during the pandemic. In terms of research, 72% of the respondents reported a decrease in research outputs (publications, presentations, etc.), with significant factors being additional time required for online teaching (68%) and home environment for remote work (68%). The working group is preparing a more detailed analysis and will conduct focus groups during the 2020–2021 academic year. My research diary entry for 9 September continued with: *Routines strengthen boundaries, provide alternative schedules, keep the focus on what I value and desire. Saying no is not enough. Doing no is the answer.*

Conclusion

In revisiting the images in my extended photo essay on the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic within our campus environment, partially reproduced here, I am aware that much is unseen, just outside of my field of vision. Canadian universities are in a holding pattern, having put in place the mechanisms by which we might operate in suspended animation online, into the (un)foreseeable future. In early October, Statistics Canada released financial projection scenarios for the university sector that predict a 2020-2021 revenue shortfall between \$377 million to \$3.4 billion CAD, depending on the scenario (Statistics Canada 2020b). As the fall term of 2020 continues, more students are returning to the UBC campus even though most courses will be taught online for the rest of the academic year. Emergency policy changes made by the Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada agency permitted many international students to maintain their visa eligibility and continue to count time toward their post-graduation work permits, even if they were studying online and outside of Canada. Since mid-October, international students are now granted an exception to enter Canada, provided that they

have a documented plan for their 14-day quarantine. UBC offers incoming students complimentary two-week self-isolation room and board packages, and similar services for any UBC community members for a fee. Recreational facilities are re-opening, and a mandatory mask-wearing policy is in place for indoor campus spaces. Graduations and other events will be held online, business as unusual.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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